

“Paper, practice, ancestry, culture”: Racial frames and contested racial/ethnic census categories

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How do individuals and groups frame their appeals to change official racial/ethnic categories and explain their perceptions of the underlying boundaries that such categories reflect? This article draws from the case of revisions to the 2030 U.S. census categories using the universe of the over 20,000 public comments submitted to the federal government in response to proposed changes. Using an integrated computational text analysis and qualitative approach, I find that three sets of strategies characterize the general deployment of racial frames across comments. The first describes the broader characteristics that are perceived to define a given category; the second grapples with the historical and contemporary nature of racial/ethnic boundaries; and the third situates the placement of a given group in the existing racial order. I then examine the use of these strategies in reference to the proposed Middle Eastern and North African category and to the existing Black/African American and Hispanic/Latino categories. Finally, I examine the resonance of particular frames and strategies by illustrating the extent to which they were submitted on behalf of organizations or duplicated widely by individual actors. Together, this study advances our broader understanding of the dynamic nature of racial/ethnic categories and the boundaries that they are perceived to represent.

Key words: race/ethnicity; demography/population.

Introduction

The official racial/ethnic census categories reflecting the demographic composition of the U.S. have undergone consistent churn, with over 25 changes over the last 200 years (U.S. Census Bureau 2023b). Since the census was first administered, new categories have been added, modified, and removed altogether—defining and redefining the *de facto* racial/ethnic labels used by government agencies, by scholars and policymakers, and by average Americans alike (Omi and Winant 2014).

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While early census categories were imposed by the state, more recent changes represent the outcome of a dynamic negotiation process between the populations that such categories are meant to represent as well as by the state actors responsible for developing and legitimating them in the first place (Mora 2014; Skrentny 2006; Strmic-Pawl, Jackson, and Garner 2018; Hochschild and Powell 2008). Successful addition of new categories depends, in part, on the framing strategies used to motivate appeals to the state, which in turn shapes both the measurement of inequality and discrimination across a number of domains as well as everyday beliefs about the racial structure (Bailey, Fialho, and Loveman 2018; Benford and Snow 2000; McCammon et al. 2007; Warikoo and De Novais 2015). Indeed, the census and the contested categories contained within it speak to the larger, ongoing racial projects at work: the ways that individuals and society make meaning out of race while organizing status and resources along racial lines (Omi and Winant 2014).

Prior work in this vein has illustrated not only the extent to which racial/ethnic categories shape our social world, but also the role of organizations and movements in helping to motivate changes over time (Mora 2014; Nobles 2000). However, the role of the public in this process is often overlooked. Nonetheless, individuals are a key part of the process of categorical negotiation and renegotiation: not only do members of the public motivate change, but it can also be hard for categories to become legitimized and widely used without at least partial acceptance from the public (Hochschild and Powell 2008). Further, census categories are coarse measures; individuals and groups do not always feel that they are adequately represented in categories, and their expressions of discontent can quickly lead to appeals for change at the organization and state levels (Mora 2014; Nobles 2000). And yet, we know little about how issues of categorical representation (and appeals to the state for changing or refashioning categories) are discussed by individuals and groups themselves.

How do individuals and groups frame census categories and the racial/ethnic boundaries they are perceived to represent? This study uses the case of revisions to the upcoming 2030 census to examine how Americans conceptualize racial/ethnic categories and negotiate changes in the public square. I focus on the enactment of new and revised categories by the Office of Management and Budget (OMB), the office responsible for determining federal regulations on the collection of race/ethnicity data, including for the census. In January 2023, the OMB proposed several initial changes to federal race/ethnicity standards for consideration for the upcoming 2030 census as well as for all federal forms that collect race/ethnicity data (i.e., school systems, civil rights law, and federal surveys such as the American Community Survey).¹ I use a unique dataset consisting of the universe of the over 20,000 public comments submitted to the OMB from January–April 2023 with feedback on proposed changes, submitted directly by members of the public. The initial OMB proposals included several key issues, including: (1) collecting race and ethnicity using one combined question (which would require combining the separate Hispanic/Latino ethnicity with other racial categories); (2) adding Middle Eastern or North African (MENA) as a new minimum required category; and (3) requiring the collection of detailed and disaggregated race and ethnicity categories by default, with a particular focus on data collection among Black/African American communities.² Finally, in March 2024, the OMB announced that they would combine race and ethnicity questions (adding Hispanic/Latino alongside other categories) and require MENA to be collected as a new standalone category, but declined to include questions focused on the descendants of enslaved Africans. Of course, at the time of comment submission, commenters did not know what the outcome of the OMB deliberation would be.

Using computational text analysis and topic modeling approaches (Grimmer, Roberts, and Stewart 2022; Nelson 2020; Roberts et al. 2014), I identify the racial frames used to discuss three focal racial/ethnic categories: MENA, Black/African American, and Hispanic/Latino.³ Further, I complement this approach with qualitative inquiry to better understand general patterns of frames and strategies that are not exclusive to any one category. I find that three sets of strategies characterize the deployment of racial frames across comments. The first strategy

focuses on *constructs* and describes group membership based on perceptions of the traits that define categories in the first place, with a particular emphasis on the racial, ethnic, cultural, and ancestral characteristics that are perceived to define a given category. The second strategy is oriented around *boundaries* and grapples both with the politics of who is (and is not) to be included as a member of a given racial/ethnic category as well as the historical stability of a given boundary. The third focuses on a population's *status* in the contemporary or historical racial order, including by detailing how categorical representation (or lack thereof) has affected experiences of inequality. These strategies are ideal types and are not mutually exclusive. In fact, I find that many individuals and organizations simultaneously used multiple strategies within a single document. In effect, in order to understand and make appeals around categorization, people tend to discuss and debate several key questions: How is a racial/ethnic category defined? Who is (and is not) part of a given racial/ethnic population? How has categorization—or its absence—affected racial and ethnic groups, and which populations have been most affected?

Further, I also illustrate that commenters systematically vary in their use of these strategies as they write appeals about different proposed category changes. For example, those writing about changes to the MENA category primarily focused on inequality as a means to argue that MENA populations should have a standalone category that is separate from the broader White category. However, such appeals tended to be inclusive and expansive in boundary-drawing and rarely sought to keep specific populations out. In contrast, those writing about changes to the Black category instead emphasized the historical legacy of slavery and Jim Crow while also advocating for changing the category altogether to differentiate between descendants of enslaved populations and Black immigrants to the U.S. Finally, those writing about the Hispanic/Latino category grappled with the ambiguous and shifting definitions of race and ethnicity as they debated the inclusion of Hispanic/Latino as a racial category rather than an ethnic one. In all, the strategy focusing on status emerged as the dominant strategy through which people tended to ground appeals, particularly with regard to the MENA and Black categories. Across all three cases, the use of various frames and strategies sheds light on how people understand the usefulness of categories in the first place as well as their perceptions of racial/ethnic difference.

Together, this study advances our broader understanding of the dynamic nature of racial/ethnic categories and the boundaries that they are perceived to represent. The revisions recently announced by the OMB—which were in part based upon the comment data used in this study—represent the most significant changes to federal standards since 1997. By understanding how processes of categorization are discussed and framed in the public square, we can better understand how individuals construct meaning out of perceived difference and the axes of variation that are perceived to matter most for defining race and ethnicity in categorical terms.

Background

Racial/ethnic categories and the census

In the U.S., federal regulations on the collection of race/ethnicity data were developed in 1977 so that this information would be collected consistently throughout the federal government, including on the decennial census. Prior to the newly released 2024 guidelines that followed the comment period detailed in this article, these regulations—which are collectively known as Statistical Policy Directive No. 15 (often shortened to SPD 15 or *Directive 15*)—had been updated just once (in 1997). The most recent proposed updates to SPD 15, which spurred the comment period, can be seen in [figure 1](#) alongside comparisons to both the 1997 requirements and the 2020 census questions.

Sociologists of race and ethnicity have long conceptualized the racial/ethnic divisions that structure groups to be the outcome of negotiations, classification struggles, and symbolic boundary construction by groups on both sides of a given divide ([Alba and Nee 2005](#); [Barth 1969](#); [Wimmer 2008](#); [Sen and Wasow 2016](#); [Lamont and Molnár 2002](#)). The method through which individuals perceive their similarities to define specific racial/ethnic groups sheds light on the

What is your race or ethnicity?
Select all that apply **AND** enter additional details in the space below. Note, you may report more than one group.

☐ **WHITE** – Provide details below.

☐ German

☐ Irish

☐ English

☐ Italian

☐ Polish

☐ French

Enter, for example, Scottish, Norwegian, Dutch, etc.

☐ **HISPANIC OR LATINO** – Provide details below.

☐ Mexican or Mexican Am.

☐ Puerto Rican

☐ Cuban

☐ American

☐ Dominican

☐ Colombian

☐ Salvadoran

Enter, for example, Guatemalan, Spaniard, Ecuadorean, etc.

☐ **BLACK OR AFRICAN AMERICAN** – Provide details below.

☐ African American

☐ Jamaican

☐ Somali

☐ Nigerian

☐ Ethiopian

☐ Haitian

Enter, for example, Ghanaian, South African, Barbadian, etc.

☐ **ASIAN** – Provide details below.

☐ Chinese

☐ Filipino

☐ Asian Indian

☐ Vietnamese

☐ Korean

☐ Japanese

Enter, for example, Pakistani, Cambodian, Hmong, etc.

☐ **MIDDLE EASTERN OR NORTH AFRICAN** – Provide details below.

☐ Lebanese

☐ Iranian

☐ Egyptian

☐ Syrian

☐ Moroccan

☐ Israeli

Enter, for example, Algerian, Iraqi, Kurdish, etc.

☐ **NATIVE HAWAIIAN OR PACIFIC ISLANDER** – Provide details below.

☐ Native Hawaiian

☐ Samoan

☐ Chamorro

☐ Tongan

☐ Fijian

☐ Marshallese

Enter, for example, Palauan, Tahitian, Chuukese, etc.

NOTE: Please answer BOTH Question 6 about Hispanic origin and Question 7 about race. For this census, Hispanic origins are not races.

Is this person of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin?

☐ **No**, not of Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish Origin

☐ Yes, Mexican, Mexican Am., Chicano

☐ Yes, Puerto Rican

☐ Yes, Cuban

☐ Yes, another Hispanic, Latino, or Spanish origin – Print, for example, Salvadoran, Dominican, Colombian, Guatemalan, Spaniard, Ecuadorean, etc.

What is this person's race?
Mark one or more boxes **AND** print origins.

☐ **White** – Print, for example, German, Irish, English, Italian, Lebanese, Egyptian, etc.

☐ **Black or African Am.** – Print, for example, African American, Jamaican, Haitian, Nigerian, Ethiopian, Somali, etc.

☐ **American Indian or Alaska Native** – Print name of enrolled or principal (tribe/s), for example, Navajo Nation, Blackfeet Tribe, Mayan, Aztec, Native Village of Barrow Inupiat Traditional Government, Nome Eskimo Community, etc.

☐ Chinese

☐ Vietnamese

☐ Native Hawaiian

☐ Filipino

☐ Korean

☐ Samoan

☐ Asian Indian

☐ Japanese

☐ Chamorro

☐ Other Asian – Print, for example, Pakistani, Cambodian, Hmong, etc.

☐ Other Pacific Islander – Print, for example, Tongan, Fijian, Marshallese, etc.

☐ **Some other race** – Print race or origin.

Are you Hispanic or Latino?

☐ No, not Hispanic or Latino

☐ Yes, Hispanic or Latino

What is your race? Select one or more.

☐ American Indian or Alaska Native

☐ Asian

☐ Black or African American

☐ Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander

☐ White

Figure 1. Comparison between (1) the OMB proposal for 2024 SPD 15 updated guidelines (left panel); (2) the 2020 census categories (center panel); and (3) the 1997 SPD 15 requirements (right panel). Source: Author recreation based on OMB press release, January 2023. Note: In addition to the minimum required categories, the census also asks if individuals identify as “Some other race,” though this information is not required outside of the census and the American community survey. This information is reflected in the 2020 census categories above.

process and practice of meaning-making. The census is a particular arm of racial construction, as the categories can shape how people self-identify and vice versa (Bailey, Fialho, and Loveman 2018; Goldberg 2016; Loveman 2005; Anderson 2015). However, enumerating populations by race/ethnicity is not neutral; federal categories can shape or reinforce divisions and may have “race-making” effects once institutionalized (Bailey, Fialho, and Loveman 2018; Lamont and Molnár 2002).

Initially, U.S. census categories were imposed purely in a “top-down” fashion, imposing both categorization and hierarchy on American populations, with profound consequences (Hochschild and Powell 2008; Haney-López 2006; Omi and Winant 2014). More recently, however, categories have changed over time as a result of a dynamic contestation process between the groups subject to classification, advocacy organizations, and the state (Mora 2014; Hochschild and Powell 2008). While the use and legitimization of census categories has historically been used to delineate citizenship and the resources that accompany it, the collection of such data has also become an essential cornerstone in studying, measuring, and remediating inequality in the U.S. For example, the federal government uses categorical race/ethnicity data to track inequality in education and employment, to monitor compliance with the Voting Rights Act, for political redistricting and congressional representation, and to fund public health programs for underserved communities, among others (U.S. Census Bureau, n.d.).

Focal categories and populations

The most significant accepted changes to SPD 15 concerned the addition of a MENA category and the combination of the race and ethnicity questions, which would include Hispanic/Latino alongside other racial/ethnic groups. Further, a large portion of the comments in the sample

focus on the rejected proposal to collect specific data on the descendants of enslaved African populations (though, for most agencies, it is mandatory to include both broad racial/ethnic categories as well as specific detailed categories; see [fig. 1](#)).

MENA individuals have long occupied an ambiguous place in the U.S. racial/ethnic structure ([Maghbouleh 2020](#); [Naber 2000](#)). Beginning in the 1910s, federal courts dictated that individuals of Syrian, Armenian, and Iranian descent were to be considered White ([Gualtieri 2001](#); [Maghbouleh 2017](#)). However, this classification has historically been precarious and at odds with the social experience that individuals of MENA-descent describe: previous research has shown that such individuals do not tend to self-identify as White and are also unlikely to be classified as White by external observers ([Maghbouleh, Schachter, and Flores 2022](#); [Maghbouleh 2020](#)). In the 2020 census, approximately 3.5 million Americans (or 1.5% of all Americans who self-identified as White) described their backgrounds using MENA regions using the detailed write-in race response ([Census Bureau 2023](#)).

The OMB has also included Hispanic as a separate ethnicity category since the first iteration of SPD 15 in 1977 (Latino was added to the category name in 1997). While, prior to the 2024 updates, Hispanic/Latino was officially designated as an ethnicity, there have also been longstanding debates about how to best represent Hispanic/Latino populations in the U.S. ([Telles 2018](#); [Mora 2014](#)). For example, a Pew survey of Hispanic/Latino-identifying adults found that over half (56%) believed that being Hispanic was a part of both their racial and ethnic background, compared to 19% who believed it was part of only their ethnic background and 11% who believed it was only part of their racial background ([Gonzalez-Barrera and Lopez 2015](#)). Likewise, the plurality of self-identified Hispanic/Latino Americans on the census identifies either as “some other race” or “two or more races” ([U.S. Census Bureau 2023a](#)). Indeed, recent experimental evidence on the potential consequences of the 2024 OMB changes suggest that the most dramatic changes to self-identification patterns would be among Hispanic/Latino Americans, including decreases in those identifying as Afro-Latino and among Indigenous Latinos ([Flores, Telles, and Ventura 2024](#)).

Finally, though the change was ultimately not accepted by the OMB, initial proposals included the question of whether and how to disaggregate among Black Americans on the census and elsewhere and if the census should include a category for the descendants of enslaved Americans. While, at present, the majority of Black Americans are the descendants of individuals who were enslaved within the U.S., there has also been significant immigration from the Caribbean and Sub-Saharan Africa that has dramatically reshaped the demography of the U.S. in recent decades ([Hackman and Overberg 2023](#); [Stockman 2019](#); [Hamilton 2020](#)). As a result, growing movements have sought to create stronger distinctions between Black Americans who are descended from enslaved American individuals and those who emigrated from other places more recently, though not without controversy ([Hackman and Overberg 2023](#); [Stockman 2019](#)).⁴ Prior literature has established meaningful inequality between Black immigrant populations and Black American descendants of enslaved populations, where Black immigrant populations tend to fare better along a number of valued life outcomes ([Massey et al. 2007](#); [Hamilton 2019](#); [Darity Jr. and Mullen 2022](#)). Further, though affirmative action policies were designed in part to compensate for historical experiences of discrimination, their benefits often extended to immigrant populations ([Waters, Kasinitz, and Asad 2014](#); [Skrentny 2001](#)), raising concerns by advocacy groups about the need for more clear delineation between populations ([Stockman 2019](#); [Hackman and Overberg 2023](#)).

Racial frames and framing strategies

To understand how appeals for categorical changes are constructed and deployed, I draw from prior literature on racial frames, which is itself a subset of a broader literature on cultural frames ([Benford and Snow 2000](#); [Feagin 2020](#); [Warikoo and De Novais 2015](#); [Yazdihia 2020](#); [Goffman 1986](#)). Questions on the ways that people participate in the social construction of race are inherently cultural and speak to the broader cognitive processes that underlie perceptions of similarity and difference ([Brubaker, Loveman, and Stamatov 2004](#); [Warikoo and De Novais 2015](#)). Racial

frames reveal how people make meaning out of their own racial position as well as the entirety of the racial structure, particularly by making certain aspects of similarity or difference more salient while downplaying others (Warikoo and De Novais 2015). For example, Yazdih (2020) likens the act of framing to a picture frame, which narrows attention on a particular image while simultaneously hiding what is outside of the frame. Concepts of race—and perceptions of racial differences—are not inherent divisions, but rather the outcome of framing that attributes groups to races and differences to racial differences (Brubaker 2006). Studying the deployment of frames to diagnose problems and propose solutions can reveal the narratives that individuals and groups construct about difference. And yet, the strategies used to frame issues need not be identical across groups. Indeed, given different histories and social positions among different contemporary racial/ethnic groups and coalitions, we might expect to see differences in how such framing is done.

In this study, I examine how appeals based on different racial/ethnic groups are constituted and deployed. Building on the discussion above, I outline general framing strategies used to negotiate with and appeal to the state: *constructs, boundaries, and status*. These strategies characterize the general use of frames across appeals and are not meant to be mutually exclusive; indeed, many individuals and organizations simultaneously leaned on multiple strategies within a single document. Together, they shed light on the meaning-making that individuals and groups engage in when discussing race, ethnicity, and categories.

The first strategy focuses on constructs: the traits and characteristics that define a racial or an ethnic group. Race and ethnicity are generally conceptualized by scholars as separate but, at times, overlapping constructs, which may be defined by ancestry, skin color, perceptions of shared culture, and nationality, among other traits. However, many groups are generally perceived using some combination of the two, and the line between a racial and an ethnic group is particularly blurry (Cornell and Hartmann 2004).

Second, racial frames and appeals may also include a discussion of boundaries. Racial boundaries describe the cognitive, social, and symbolic divisions that are perceived to distinguish between various populations (Brubaker, Loveman, and Stamatov 2004; Lamont and Molnár 2002; Wimmer 2008). In some cases, divisions can become entrenched in the public mind: some racial boundaries, such as the boundary that has historically defined Blackness in the U.S., are considered to be particularly rigid (Davis 2001). On the other hand, others are “blurred,” with porous edges and ambiguous divisions between those who are and are not members (Alba 2005).

Finally, a third strategy, status, centers on the social position of a given group, either in contemporary contexts or over time. Here, existing sociological work focuses on racial status and positioning as key aspects shaping group perceptions of themselves and others (Jones 2022). Each racial/ethnic group has its own unique history within the U.S. with regards to formal categorization, state control, and experiences of inequality (Hochschild and Powell 2008; Lee and Bean 2004). As a result of these divergent experiences of marginalization and hierarchy, we might expect that the use of frames focusing on status and inequality might also differ across racial/ethnic groups.

Data and methods

Data for this study were obtained directly from [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov), which hosts public comments on a range of issues that are undergoing policy changes at the federal level. The full sample for this study includes all 20,255 submitted comments on the proposed OMB race/ethnicity changes. Figure S1 displays a flowchart description of analyses. This study uses structural topic modeling (STM), a computational technique that identifies latent themes (known as topics), or words that tend to co-occur, across documents based on a predetermined number of topics (Roberts et al. 2014). Sociologists of culture and race/ethnicity, among others, have used topic modeling to uncover framing techniques from large corpora of data (DiMaggio, Nag, and Blei 2013), which can be augmented and refined using deep reading as well as qualitative memos and coding (Karell

and Freedman 2019; Nelson 2020). I leverage a computational grounded theory approach (Nelson 2020), which involved using computational methods to sift through the large corpus of documents while also conducting deep reads of the documents themselves to develop theory regarding their contents and establish patterns. Following this work, I refer to the topics generated by the STM as *frames*. Each document can be represented with a topic score that illustrates the prevalence of various topics in a given document. Individual documents can be mapped to any number of topics, and the sum of all topic prevalences for a given document is 1.

To conduct the STM, I first created a de-duplicated subset of comments that retained the first instance of all exact or near duplicates but did not include all subsequent duplicated comments.⁵ Among documents in the analytic sample, the total number of exact or near duplicates was 15,465 (14,179 exact duplicates and 1286 near duplicates), leaving 4781 unique documents.⁶ I used standard preprocessing for the documents: all text was lowercased and stemmed, with all stop words removed (Roberts et al. 2014).⁷ Based on four conventionally used fit statistics (see fig. S2), I determined that the best fit for the corpus of data was 55 topics, of which I retained 43 that were substantively meaningful and related to the outcomes of interests.⁸ Next, after a suitable number of topics were determined, I projected all of the topics onto the 20,244 documents such that document-specific values of the prevalence of each topic could be determined, including for the duplicate comments.

To name each frame, I first conducted a close read of the top documents for each topic before settling on a frame description that best encompassed (1) the top documents for a given topic and (2) words that are particularly frequent and exclusive (FREX; Roberts et al. 2014) to a given STM-generated topic. As prior work on topic models has noted, naming a topic is a qualitative, iterative decision process that is subject to human discretion based on my interpretation of the FREX words and the documents themselves (Nelson 2020; Wetts 2020). As such, there is room for differences in interpretations in the substantive meaning of all STM-generated topics. In addition, because comments written about the same proposed change tended to share lexical similarity, some of the STM-generated topics reflect references to a specific racial/ethnic group while others focused on a broader theme. During my close reads of each of the STM-generated topics, I also looked for other linguistic patterns, taking notes and memos that chronicled my own coding of these documents.

Given the large number of frames identified by the STM, I also examine co-occurrence patterns across groups of frames to better understand how they are deployed across comment types. To do so, I use principal component analysis to display a scatterplot with topics organized along the first two principal component dimensions derived from the correlation matrix across the 20,244 documents and 55 topics, following Wetts (2020). From these findings, I examine the clusters that emerged to determine which frames tend to co-occur within documents.

The core of my analysis focuses on how comment-writers engaged with the question of changes to the focal categories of MENA, Black/African American, and Hispanic/Latino. To do so, it was necessary to examine the contents of the comments to determine which racial/ethnic category each comment is in reference to. I identified all comments that included specific keywords referencing a given racial/ethnic group. Keywords were constructed using current and proposed OMB definitions for each racial/ethnic group (see Table S4).

Both topic modeling and examining frame co-occurrence patterns have limitations. Topic modeling approaches indicate when words tend to co-occur within frames, and the co-occurrence analysis illustrates when particular sets of frames co-occur within the same documents. However, neither method is able to shed light on the context or valence of particular frames or clusters of frames. To better understand these patterns, I also augmented descriptions of the frames and patterns with my own inductive interpretations; I arrived at these conclusions by iterating between the computationally-derived information (e.g., topics and associated FREX words as well as output from the principal component clustering analysis) and my own memos and perceptions of the substantive meaning of comments and relationship to broader sociological theory (Nelson 2020). Using this approach, I developed three general strategies and orientations that together

Table 1. Comment category classifications.

	Inclusive of other categories		Exclusive to category	
	N	%	N	%
Middle Eastern or North African (MENA)	15,803	78.1%	13,803	68.2%
White	501	2.5%	41	0.2%
Black or African American	4,167	20.6%	1,672	8.3%
American Indian or Alaska Native	141	0.7%	2	0%
Asian	436	2.2%	31	0.2%
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander	103	0.5%	5	0%
Hispanic or Latino	1,892	9.3%	155	0.8%
Multiple categories	—	—	2,947	14.6%
No categories	1,588	7.8%	1,588	7.8%

Note: Inclusive of other categories indicates when a comment was either fully or partially in reference to a given category (i.e., a comment referencing both MENA and White categories would be reflected twice, once each in the MENA and White category rows). Exclusive to category indicates when a comment was only in reference to a given category, with comments about multiple categories tabulated in a separate row.

characterize the frames; this allowed me to aggregate the patterns across the 43 diverse frames into clusters that reveal more discernible patterns about how people and organizations frame appeals around race/ethnicity and categorical inclusion.

Results

Identifying frames and framing strategies

Before examining the contents of the comments and the frames deployed within them, I first examine the frequency of mention of all racial/ethnic categories across comments (see Table 1). Importantly, comments could be in reference to multiple categories or changes. The bulk of comments submitted to the OMB included keywords about the MENA category change: 15,803 comments (78%) of the analytic sample were categorized as being either fully or partially in reference to a potential addition of a MENA category. Comments including keywords about changes to the Black racial category represented a smaller subset of comments (4,167, or 21% of comments). In addition, 1,892 (9%) of comments concerned changes to the Hispanic/Latino ethnic category and relevant proposed changes.⁹ About 15% of comments focused on at least two racial/ethnic categories. Figures 2 and 3 shows the probability of different frame occurrences across all documents (fig. 2) and the de-duplicated subset (fig. 3), which is further disaggregated by focal racial/ethnic category.

Across comments, the STM yielded a range of racial frames used when making appeals or when rejecting proposed changes. Table S1 in the appendix also lists all of the frames, while Table S2 lists the 15 most common frames along with representative quotes and FREX words. First, I examine the relationship between the frames. Figure 4 illustrates similarity between frames along the first two principal component dimensions derived from a correlation matrix across all comments and topics. Topics that tend to co-occur within documents will be closer in the two-dimensional space, while topics that share little overlap will be located on more distant ends of the figure. The frames themselves can be separated into three co-occurrence clusters: one located between the leftmost quadrants, one stretching diagonally across the top right quadrant, and another stretching diagonally across the bottom right quadrant. These clusters approximately align with the focal racial/ethnic categories in this study. The cluster of frames that collectively represents the largest number of documents in the sample (between the two quadrants on the left) tends to focus on broad issues related to contemporary MENA inequality and the establishment of new boundaries to do so, often with explicit references to the proposed MENA category. On the

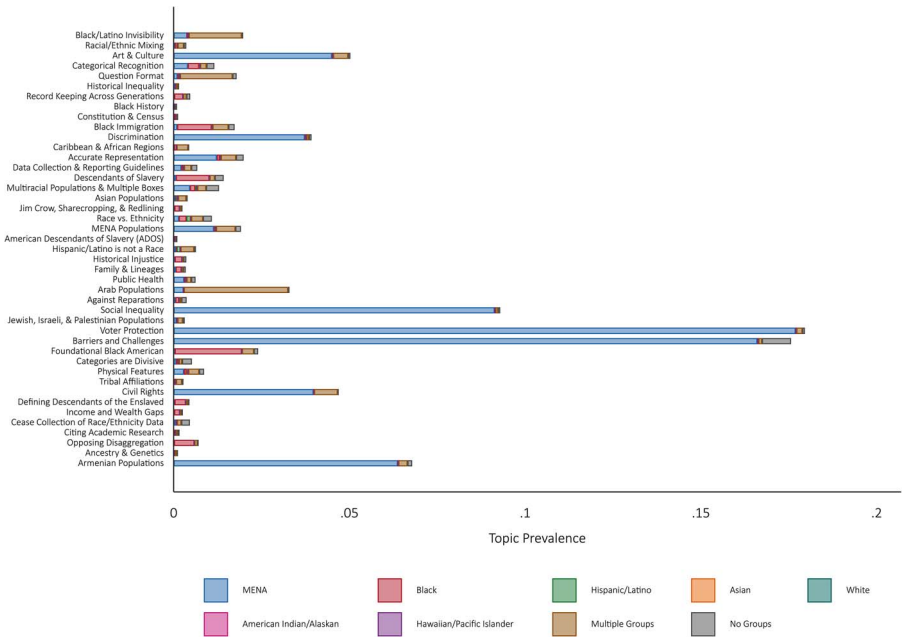


Figure 2. Topic prevalence across comments, disaggregated by comment racial/ethnic category (full sample, $n = 20,244$). Notes: Each comment is classified entirely or partly with each of the topics such that, for each document, the sum of topics 1–55 is equal to 1. Notes: Each comment is classified entirely or partly with each of the topics such that, for each document, the sum of topics 1–55 is equal to 1.

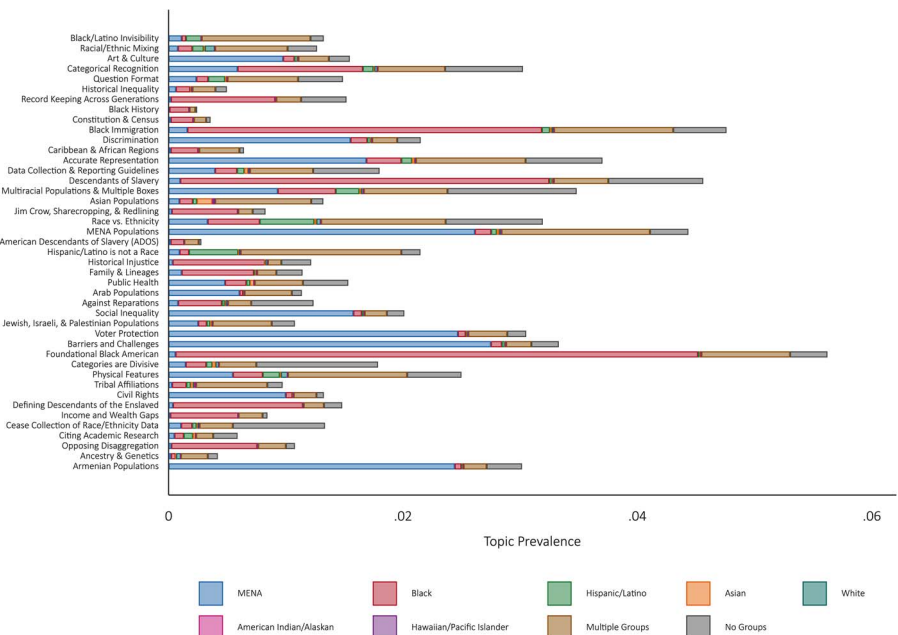


Figure 3. Topic prevalence across comments, disaggregated by comment racial/ethnic category (de-duplicated sample, $n = 4781$). Notes: Each comment is classified entirely or partly with each of the topics such that, for each document, the sum of topics 1–55 is equal to 1.

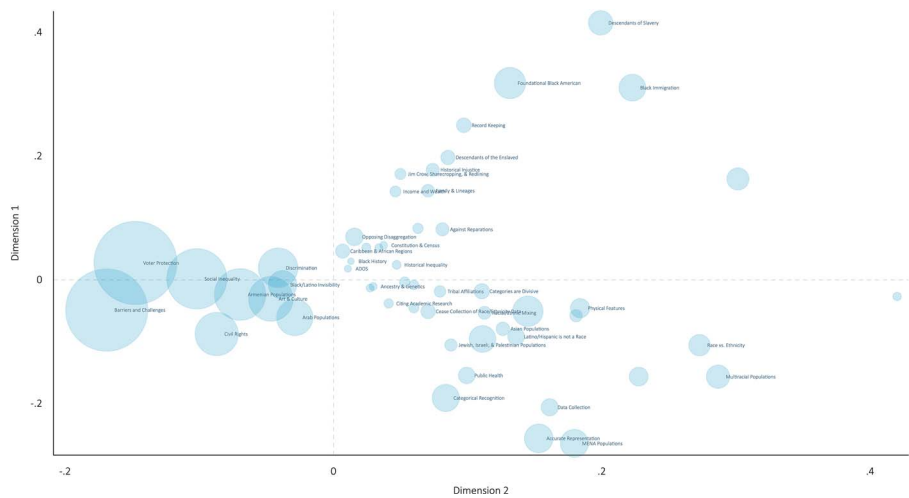


Figure 4. Scatterplot of first and second principal components derived from frame correlation matrix. Note: All topics are weighted by topic size. Marker labels are displayed in largest text possible that avoids significant visual overlap between markers.

other hand, the top right quadrant contains frames that tend to reference the Black and African American racial category and the proposed efforts to disaggregate within the Black community, including references to historical oppression. Finally, the quadrant that extends through the bottom right quadrant primarily focuses on Hispanic/Latino populations and categories. These patterns of clusters suggests that comments and frames tended to share the most similarity and co-occurrence patterns within (rather than across) racial/ethnic categories.

Further, [figs. 5 and 6](#) displays bivariate associations between frame prevalence and (1) the category a given comment referenced ([fig. 5](#)), (2) whether or not a given comment was a near or exact duplicate of another comment ([fig. 6](#)), and (3) whether a given comment was submitted on behalf of an organization rather than an individual ([fig. 6](#)). Further, [Table 2](#) lists the most common frames for each of the focal categories. As can be seen in both the tables and in the figures—and as will be discussed in more detail in the next sections—the frames deployed tended to differ across racial/ethnic categories. While not the main focus of this study, [fig. 6](#) also illustrates which messages are particularly likely to be (1) duplicated by individual commenters or (2) submitted on behalf of organizations.¹⁰ While neither metric is a perfect measurement of the resonance or spread of particular frames amongst the general public (particularly given that these comments already reflect a select group of Americans with the interest to submit and the knowledge about how to do so), these results paint a picture of the extent to which some messaging strategies held more influence on commenters than others.

Based in part on the frames identified in the STM along with my interpretation of the patterns and themes, I observe three general sets of strategies that span across racial/ethnic categories, which I explain in more detail in the next sections. These are ideal types and are therefore not mutually exclusive; for example, many comments included a combination of several strategies in making appeals. In what follows, I examine the use of racial strategies and frames across the three focal racial/ethnic groups. Because—as shown in [fig. 4](#)—these strategies tended to be similar within a given racial/ethnic group, I order the remainder of the results section by racial/ethnic group rather than by framing orientation. I begin with the MENA category because the majority of comments focused on MENA populations. Next, I consider comments focusing on Black populations (the 2nd most commonly referenced category/group) followed by those discussing Hispanic/Latino populations (the 3rd most commonly referenced category/group).

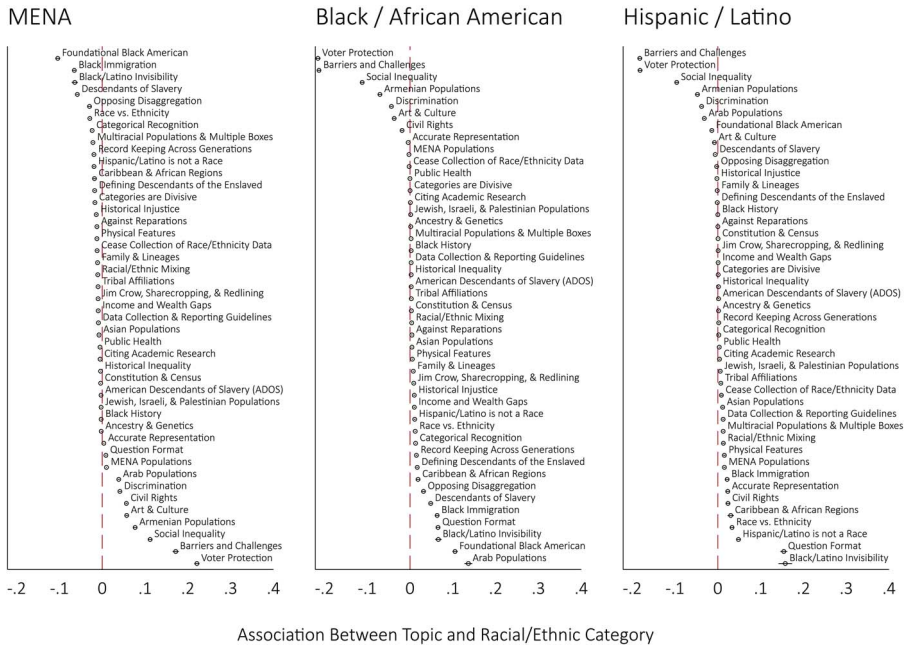


Figure 5. Coefficient plot illustrating bivariate association between frames and racial/ethnic category.



Figure 6. Coefficient plot illustrating bivariate association between frames and comment type (duplicates and organizations).

Table 2. Most common frames across comments, by racial/ethnic category.

Rank	Obs.	Topic number	Topic Name	FREX words
Panel A: MENA				
1	3538	33	Voter protection	voter, protect, decad, littl, polic, govern, suppress, direct, inequit, face
2	3320	34	Barriers and challenges	barrier, inequ, challeng, face, linguist, sever, hinder, troubl, lack, pictur
3	1826	31	Social inequality	educ, student, mental, expuls, suspens, school, prevent, health, mortal, advoc
4	1275	54	Armenian populations	armenian, armenianamerican, checkbox, subcategori, largest, insist, must, top, questionnair, size
5	901	4	Art & culture	art, messag, situat, equal, treat, fund, shape, perceiv, voic, suppos
Panel B: Black / African American				
1	381	35	Foundational Black American	foundat, fba, lineag, reclassifi, classifi, freedmen, retir, mulatto, built, amalgam
2	196	11	Black immigration	call, black, african, usa, immigr, separ, diaspora, melan, caribbean, want
3	191	16	Descendants of slavery	descend, slaveri, design, chattel, specif, lineag, identifi, ado, describ, institut
4	116	50	Opposing disaggregation	freedman, descript, confus, nonimmigr, alloc, caus, oppos, name, dehuman, consider
5 (Tie)	64	5	Categorical recognition	recogn, respect, distinct, ident, countri, other, deserv, oppress, proper, uniqu
5 (Tie)	64	46	Defining descendants of the enslaved	defin, enslav, within, minimum, describ, contin, slaveri, approach, acknowledg, relat
Panel C: Hispanic / Latino				
1	24	20	Race vs. ethnicity	race, construct, racial, concept, ethnic, confus, latinohispan, defin, characterist, disagre
2	21	23	Hispanic/Latino is not a race	latino, latin, mestizo, afrolatino, latinx, hispan, hispaniclatino, spanish, afro, indigen
3	10	17	Multiracial populations & multiple boxes	box, option, census, choos, check, multiraci, form, feel, count, choic

Notes: Because the Hispanic/Latino category included comparatively fewer overall comments than the MENA and Black/African American category changes, respectively, I only include the top three frames.

Framing appeals for a new MENA category: Social inequality and expansive boundaries

The majority of comments submitted to the OMB focused on the question of whether MENA ought to be included as a new racial/ethnic category. In examining both the most common frames and those most associated with the category (see Table 2 and fig. 5), as well as from my analysis of the documents and patterns, I find that the frames primarily used to describe MENA categorization focus on the politics of invisibility and social exclusion, prioritizing contemporary inequality in diagnosing the problem of lack of MENA categorical representation. Further, such frames tended to include language suggesting relatively inclusive boundaries, though commenters also debated which groups should serve as the example populations on census forms.

Frames such as *Barriers and Challenges*, *Voter Protection*, and *Social Inequality* were frequently used together with references to the MENA category. These comments discuss the politics of invisibility and social exclusion, prioritizing the fact of present-day inequality in explaining why MENA groups should be counted with a standalone category. For example, the most common frame used to make appeals around MENA populations (and one of the most commonly used frames overall) was *Voter Protection*. Comments associated with this frame argued that, without classification under Directive 15, it is difficult for a given population to have full government representation and protection from discrimination. As an example, one representative comment focused on discrimination across a range of sectors:

MENA communities have faced discrimination for decades with little to no protection from the government. We know that we experience voter suppression, discriminatory policing, inequitable access to government programs and services, but we cannot tell the stories because we are considered as White under Directive 15

In emphasizing the “stories” that cannot be told without accurate representation, the comment-writer motivates changes to the census categories by illustrating the wide-reaching impacts of a lack of formal categorization for MENA communities. These impacts range from voter suppression to “inequitable access to government programs and services.” In a similar response, another respondent—in a comment primarily classified by the STM under the *Social Inequality* frame—wrote:

Directive 15s systemic exclusion of MENA communities’ masks various health and educational disparities and prevents advocates from seeking government support. Our communities cannot tell the stories of school suspensions and expulsions. We cannot tell the stories of maternal mortality. We cannot tell the stories of inadequate mental health services.

As with the previous example, the writer leans on the experience of categorical invisibility and contemporary inequality as primary motivating factors towards including MENA as a racial category in future data collection efforts, particularly when government support is at stake.

In addition to a dimension of racial framing oriented around status and inequality to diagnose the problem of lack of representation, comment-writers also engaged with the process of defining boundaries. This was especially prevalent among those writing about the MENA category because, unlike for Black and Hispanic/Latino populations (which have been represented on the census for some decades), the updated Directive 15 represents the first instance of specific categorical inclusion for MENA populations in the U.S. As a result, commenters engaged with the question of which populations should be included and which should serve as the representative examples. In discussing and debating these examples, one comment-writer—in a document primarily classified under the *Armenian Populations* frame—discussed category boundaries as they pertained to the examples:

... Armenian-Americans are among the top 3 largest MENA communities in terms of population size and must have that reflected with an Armenian checkbox on the upcoming Census form...

In this passage, the comment-writer focuses not on the boundary defining the MENA category, but rather on the importance of including specific and populous groups (in this case, Armenian populations) in the detailed options. In particular, the comment-writer argues that population size should dictate how examples and detailed ethnicities are collected and that Armenians should be included as a detailed option given its population size. This was true throughout comments, as respondents debated how including (or excluding) particular populations from the example categories might affect resource distribution. Indeed, beyond the categories themselves,

the choice of specific example ethnicities shapes how people understand the contours of a given racial/ethnic group and which populations are considered to be representative.

Finally, though most comments concerning the MENA category prioritized a discussion of social inequality and expansive boundaries, some did attend to the question of defining the category, such as by discussing physical features such as skin color. For example, a subset of comments were submitted by self-identified MENA individuals and referred to physical appearance to make appeals:

As an Iraqi refugee . . . I don't see myself as white, or black, or anything on the census...In the US I am considered white, and that is far from the truth . . . Hell, I don't even look white. I have medium darker skin and dark features.

Here, the author leans on descriptions of physical features: because they don't "look White" and have "medium darker skin and dark features," they have struggled with feeling invisible due to a lack of categorization. However, perhaps surprisingly given the focus on race and ethnicity, discussions of skin tone and physical features were comparatively less common overall.

In all, the documents appealing to the state about the inclusion of a MENA category include a relatively coherent set of strategies: (1) framing around contemporary inequality and the barriers that lack of categorical recognition introduces and (2) drawing generally inclusive boundaries around who could be included in this new MENA category, though individuals and organizations still debated which populations should serve as examples on forms. In general, such comments tended to focus on the fact of categorical invisibility for MENA groups as a key reason motivating their inclusion moving forward.

Historical oppression and boundary contraction: Defining a Black American category

On the other hand, the second most commonly referenced racial/ethnic category was the Black-/African American category. Similar to those referencing the MENA category, comments tended to focus on the role of inequality while simultaneously grappling with the question of boundaries. However, commenters also prioritized historical inequality (rather than contemporary inequality) as a reason for needing a separate, disaggregated category. For example, a subset of comments included appeals for a separate racial/ethnic category that distinguished more recent Black immigrants from Black Americans who are descended from American slavery. In attempting to make these distinctions, one commenter—in a document classified primarily under the *Foundational Black American* topic—wrote:

Black Americans who can trace their family lineage back 150 Or slaves in the United States of America should be referred to as FOUNDATIONAL BLACK AMERICANS. We have our own culture and history. We are not immigrants. Foundational Black Americans are the foundation of the United States of America. We built it from scratch and it's wealth...

In general, unlike with the MENA category, individuals advocating for changes to the Black/African American category blended discourse of historical inequality with boundary contraction, suggesting that different Black populations should be counted independently *because* they have distinct experiences of historical inequality, which extend to today in their impacts. In contrast, those writing about the MENA category tended to argue that a lack of categorization meant that it was difficult to discern how much inequality the MENA community has faced. Further, when referencing Black American populations, such claims appeared, at times, motivated in part by a perceived threat to scarce resources (such as in affirmative action contexts) that might be protected by more narrow boundaries:

... they want to have all the benefits and rights our ancestors fought and died for. Whenever [people] in Caribbean say they're black what they're saying is, I can take what's yours I can take with what belongs to you. I can get the same privileges and resources you get. we are letting them use our name and they get to take resources and benefits that were meant for us. when they're ready to go back, then Nigerian Canadian Jamaican Haiti or whatever we're still going to be black...

Here, in arguing that Black immigrant groups "want to have all the benefits and rights" that prior generations of Black Americans had fought and died for, this commenter suggests that appeals for categorical recognition should also take resources into account. Further, the commenter suggests that, for some groups, identification as Black might be strategic and a means to take advantage of certain privileges and resources.

Although the orientation strategies of constructs, boundaries, and status reflect ideal types, overlaps exist even within the same comments. For example, in drawing boundaries that explicitly include some populations while keeping others out, commenters at times needed to rely on the definitions of the category to do so. Consider the following associated passage:

I can't go to Haiti and call myself, Haitian I can't go to Nigeria and call myself Nigerian. I can go to Cuba and call myself Cuban... You might have a passport or you might have been born here so you might be black on paper now, but you're not black in practice you're not black in culture you're not black in ancestry. you are a immigrant ...

In this excerpt, the comment writer asserts that Black immigrants are not Black in practice, ancestry, or culture, and instead only "Black on paper," asserting that there is a specific legitimacy that can only be accomplished when the conditions of common practice, culture, and ancestry are met. Here, the commenter not only defines the perceived boundaries of this group, but also defines the conditions that, in the view of the commenter, define the category. In blending a boundary orientation with a discussion of constructs, the commenter creates a definition of race that also takes culture into account. Still, it is important to acknowledge that these definitions were not universally accepted or agreed upon. In the passage below, a commenter pushes back on appeals to meaningfully change the name and description of the Black/African American category by holding that "slavery is not our ethnicity":

I oppose changing the name, description, and definition of the race category "Black or African American" for federal data collection, including for the U.S. Census... Though our ancestors endured slavery, slavery is not our ethnicity, and it is dehumanizing and inaccurate to make "slavery or slaves" a race category or an ethnic identifier...

In another example of motivating change using a combination of orientations, one commenter—in a document primarily categorized under the *American Descendants of Slavery* frame—blended both boundary contraction with status and inequality-based distinctions:

All black and brown people are not the same... Our ethnic experience and lineage is unique and we deserve to be recognized separate and apart from those who chose to immigrate to this land. Increasing numbers of immigrants from the African/Caribbean diaspora have severely limited the effectiveness of legislation, programs, and set asides intended to remedy the affliction that racism, segregation, denied opportunities, redlining, gentrification, and many other systemic constraints that have kept us collectively at the bottom of society.

Here, in addition to drawing boundaries that separate immigrants from African and Caribbean regions to those that descended from slavery, the author also uses differences in experiences of inequality to do so.

Finally, I also observed that the usage of these frames differs across categories: while commenters writing about the MENA category center contemporary inequality, those writing about the Black/African American category instead reference historical differences. Each use these references to advocate for a new formation of a category. For the MENA category, this entailed a new, bright boundary that separates MENA individuals from the broader White category that argued to be necessary because of ongoing, contemporary inequality between MENA and White populations. For the Black category, commenters instead suggested disaggregation based on descent and family history, suggesting that these groups should be considered separate *because* of their differing histories of inequality that extend to today in their impacts. While those writing about the MENA category tended to reference inequality but without referencing a specific group threatening scarce resources, those writing about the Black/African American category were more likely to suggest that resources for the community descended from enslaved populations might be threatened if Black immigrants could claim them as well.

Ambiguous constructs, ambiguous boundaries: Framing the Hispanic/Latino category

What is a race or an ethnicity, how are they different, and how should we categorize populations using these constructs? As shown in [fig. 1](#), the terms “race” and “ethnicity” are not defined for census-takers in the 2024 OMB updates. By leaving these terms ambiguous, there is space for individuals and groups to construct their own definitions of the traits that they perceive to define a population and its corresponding category. A subset of comments interrogated the Hispanic/Latino category using orientations that overwhelmingly focused on constructs, shedding light on the similarities and differences between how people conceptualize the previously ethnic category of Hispanic/Latino relative to other racial categories. Frames such as *Race vs. Ethnicity*, *Physical Features*, and *Hispanic/Latino is not a Race* highlighted the ambiguous and oft-debated nature of race and ethnicity as constructs. As a set, they include language that often refers to the fact that these are social constructs, and yet the comments also suggested a general sense of uncertainty about how race and ethnicity should be defined.

For example, examinations of comments associated with the *Race vs. Ethnicity* frame reveal perceptions of the ambiguous position of Hispanic/Latino populations and the use of conceptual ideas of race and ethnicity to clarify it. Associated comments include passages such as the following example:

... I do not agree with this new proposal because the terms Hispanic or Latino do not belong to the category of race. I think the word “ethnicity” should be considered as an option in the form. For example, the word ethnicity means “community defined by cultural, social and linguistic affinities” which differs from the word “race” which refers to “phenotypic characteristics”. I kindly suggest keeping the word “race” but also including “ethnicity” as two different concepts.

In general, commenters used the opportunity to appeal to the OMB to construct definitions of race and ethnicity in the service of making their broader points about the Hispanic/Latino category. In particular, this commenter offers a definition for ethnicity—which, broadly speaking, they define as containing cultural, social, and linguistic characteristics—and race, which the commenter defines using phenotype in order to reject the proposed change.

The portrayal of Hispanic/Latino as an ethnic category that encompasses multiple racial groups is evident in other frames and comments as well. Because many individuals who identify as Hispanic/Latino also identify with other racial groups, comment-writers tended to focus on multiracial individuals and advocate for methods that would ensure that there would not be erasure of communities that identify as both Black and Hispanic/Latino. In fact, nearly 80% (1482) of the 1892 comments fully or partially in reference to the Hispanic/Latino category also referenced potential changes to the Black/African American category and to Black communities.

For example, close reads of the *Multiracial Populations & Multiple Boxes* and *Black/Latino Invisibility* frames reveal deep concern about the consequences of changing OMB guidelines to include Hispanic/Latino as a race:

Latino is not a race. There are folks who are black, white, indigenous, Asian and mixed race who can identify as Latino. This change to how race is viewed is racist and harmful. ... This is incredibly harmful to black Latinos who are systematically ignored in Latin America and in the US...

Here, the commenter worries that this “change to how race is viewed” could be harmful specifically to the Black and Latino population of the U.S., with the potential for collateral consequences on Latin American populations as well. What is further evident from these discussions are that some commenters have firm views on non-overlapping definitions of race and ethnicity, which may complicate efforts by the OMB to combine race and ethnicity categories into a single race/ethnicity set.

While the bulk of comments on the Hispanic/Latino category focused on the debate about the constructs of race and ethnicity, others also asked how the boundaries of this category should be drawn. Brazilians, in particular, appeared to inspire considerable confusion and debate about whether or not they should be considered Latino given language differences. For example, consider the following two passages:

What will be the case for someone from Brazil? They are not Spanish speakers. But are they Latino?

I suggest that the Spanish designation be removed from the category "Hispanic or Latino" and that the Brazilian classification be incorporated in its stead... Brazilian culture shares more similarities with Latino culture than European, and Brazil is a Latin American nation. It is important to note that "Latino" is a cultural identifier and encompasses people from a diverse range of cultural backgrounds who have settled in Latin America.

Here, both sets of comments ask about specific population inclusion under the broader Hispanic/Latino category (though, importantly, they also draw from their perceived definitions of the category constructs). In this case, both comments reference Brazilian populations, who share many characteristics with populations that are more typically associated with the Hispanic/Latino category. However, given their linguistic differences, the extent to which the OMB intended for them to be included within the category is unclear (Pew Research Center 2024).

Ancestry, race, and ethnicity

Finally, in comments that were not necessarily in reference to any racial/ethnic group in particular, some commenters asked how perceptions of categories might change with the advent of genetic ancestry tests such as those produced by 23andMe and [Ancestry.com](https://www.ancestry.com). These tests provide consumers with information about their genome that many conflate with race and ethnicity (Roth and Ivermark 2018). Such frames tended to focus on the definition of race and ethnicity, drawing primarily from a strategy based on constructs. For example, some commenters grappled with the possibility that genetic ancestry test results might shape census responses:

... With the growing popularity of online ancestry services such as "Ancestry" & "23andme" many people have found ancestry from multiple world regions often with detailed geographic origin of DNA to very small percentages. Someone who is 60% Samoan, 20% Chinese, 5% Spanish, 3% Irish, 3% Swedish, 5% Nigerian, 2% Vietnamese, and 2% other may well tick all White, Black, Hispanic, and Asian boxes when clearly their ancestry is overwhelmingly Pacific Islander and Chinese...

Here, the commenter considers the ambiguity of ancestry and how genetic ancestry tests might shape responses on a version of the census that allowed for detailed responses with multiple racial and ethnic groups. This echoes concerns by scholars who noted that the 2020 census inclusion of the term “origins” may have prompted individuals to include information from genetic ancestry tests or other sources that may not reflect how they self-identify in most other settings (Starr and Pao 2024; Wang 2021).

Discussion

The U.S. census is a project of race-making that is co-constructed by citizens and the state; it is the product of a negotiation process whose output depends, in part, on the frames deployed by those seeking to change the categories at hand (Mora 2014; Nobles 2000). Such categories have far-reaching consequences: they have the potential to shape the distribution of resources and protections across racial lines and even to remake the way that people think about racial membership and meaning (Bailey, Fialho, and Loveman 2018; Nobles 2000; Omi and Winant 2014). This study examines the universe of publicly posted comments submitted to the OMB about proposed changes to federal race/ethnicity reporting standards, some of which will be implemented on the upcoming 2030 census and on all federal forms, with the potential to shape numerous aspects of social science research and broader understandings of race and ethnicity.

In particular, I focus on three groups with divergent histories of classification, status, and social closure in the U.S.: MENA, Black, and Hispanic/Latino populations. I surface three general strategies used to appeal to the OMB on the topic of changing racial/ethnic categories. These strategies span racial/ethnic groups, each referencing and shaped by a given population's social positioning and history within the U.S. racial structure. These strategies are evidence that, while the histories and positions of different racial/ethnic groups vary, questions about categorical belonging and racial/ethnic membership tends to fall under (at least) one of these broad orienting strategies. First, people define and debate groups based on perceptions of the constructs that define race and ethnicity in the first place. This appeared to be more straightforward for some groups than others; for example, the bulk of comments on the Hispanic/Latino category focused on whether it should (or should not) continue to be held as a separate ethnic category. Second, people drew boundaries around a particular category. In some cases, such as in reference to MENA groups, this tended to be more inclusive, while those writing about the Black racial category tended to contract the boundaries to make them more exclusive. Finally, commenters positioned racial/ethnic groups based on perceived status and experiences of inequality. As an example, MENA advocates tended to focus on contemporary inequality to advocate for relatively expansive boundaries, while those writing about the Black category used the fact of historical inequality to justify contracted boundaries and to protect against perceived threats to scarce resources. Across comments, status was by far the dominant strategy used to frame appeals.

The politics of if a population is defined more by shared ancestry, skin color, language, or culture; who does and does not belong within its borders; and to what extent it has experienced inequality tells us much about racial conceptualizations and meaning-making in contemporary American society. In particular, I combine literatures on the construction of race and ethnicity with literature on cultural and racial frames to examine how racial/ethnic groups make sense of themselves and others (Omi and Winant 2014; Warikoo and De Novais 2015), illustrating the process of “bottom-up” advocacy at work in reshaping classification norms (Hochschild and Powell 2008). Overall, the frames and strategies identified in this work illustrate the process of racial formation, with consequences on the official categorization processes for the entire U.S. Further, this study also sheds light on public opinion of the categories that have come to define a number of aspects of American life. These definitions illustrate whether and how people view categories as modes of measuring or as a response to inequality, in addition to the extent to which people believe that they reflect meaningful divisions between groups. This study extends and builds upon prior work that examines historical trends in how movements not only negotiated

for categorical recognition from the state, but also used frames to legitimate the use of such categories among members of populations that may not have considered themselves under the same umbrella category (Davis 2001; Mora 2014; Nobles 2000). While the goal of this study is not to directly measure levels of support for various OMB proposals, the underlying comment data used for this study suggests considerable—albeit heterogenous—support for changes to the 1997 standards.

There are a number of limitations that warrant addressing. First, individuals and groups were not constrained to only writing comments on their own self-identified racial/ethnic group, and most did not directly provide a racial/ethnic identification. Given uncertainty in the surname matching methods, this precludes a satisfying assessment of how different racial groups themselves frame issues, though I include some coarse approximations of individual-level race/ethnicity in the appendix. Future work should consider not only how a broader set of individuals (for example, those who did not make public appeals by submitting comments to the OMB) frame racial/ethnic categorical boundaries, but also the extent to which specific frames tend to be more or less useful in gaining the support of the state actors responsible for enacting and legitimizing these categories. Finally, an important limitation of this study overall is that comment-writers represent a select, motivated portion of the population who have chosen to submit comments to a government agency. Even then, finding a large amount of support for one proposed change over another does not tell us if the American public writ large would prefer such a change. Further, respondents may not hold accurate views about the current state of affairs regarding the census or broader patterns of inequality. All told, the submitted comments illustrate how, for a motivated subset of the American population, appeals about racial/ethnic categories are motivated and framed.

We are at a critical and pressing juncture when considering the collection of race/ethnicity data in the U.S. The recently announced changes to SPD 15 represent the first such change since 1997, and the 2030 census updates will dramatically reshape how race/ethnicity data will be collected in the U.S. for years to come.

Endnotes

1. The full text of the call for comments can be found at <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2023/01/27/2023-01635/initial-proposals-for-updating-ombs-race-and-ethnicity-statistical-standards>
2. Hereafter, I use the terms “Black” and “African American” interchangeably, which reflects their use in OMB regulations and on the U.S. census.
3. As I explain in more details in the methods section, comments on the MENA, Black, and Hispanic/Latino category changes collectively represented the vast majority of all comments, while comments referencing other recognized race/ethnicity groups were much smaller in sample (<1000 comments; <5% of the analytic sample).
4. The largest of these movements calls itself the “American Descendants of Slavery,” or ADOS, but the sentiments expressed by similar groups about distinctions between Black descendants of the enslaved and other Black immigrants have been expressed for decades (Stockman 2019). Other groups present in the census comment data include the “Foundational Black Americans,” or FBA.
5. I identified exact and near-duplicates as those that either (1) contained exact duplicated text or (2) shared over 0.999 cosine similarity, which often entailed otherwise identical text with a single word changed (such as a name signed at the bottom of a document).
6. Further, while examining the contents of the documents, I encountered several that suggested that the duplicates were the result of communities distributing scripts for individuals to copy and paste into the call for comments (rather than, for example, computationally submitted by a bot). Several submitted comments included instruction text received from

a third party, with text such as “Copy the message below and paste it on the OMB site by clicking the button below” included alongside links to the call for comments.

7. Through cleaning and STM document fitting steps, a very small number of documents were dropped from analyses by the model (11 documents, <0.05% of the full sample).
8. For example, a number of commenters attached documents to their submissions. The STM then picked up the similarity of word usage these comments, resulting in a topic on attachments and language such as “please see attached”. Given the lack of clear sociological relevance, I did not conduct further analyses on topics of this nature.
9. I focus on these three categories because they collectively represent the vast majority of frames.
10. When commenters submitted comments, they were given the option to either provide their name or the name of an organization to submit on behalf of. Here, I consider comments that were directly submitted by or on behalf of organizations. However, this does not include scripts or text that were distributed by organizations but then submitted by individuals under their own names (or anonymously).

About the author

Marissa E. Thompson is an assistant professor of sociology at Columbia University. Her research addresses social policy questions at the intersection of race/ethnicity, education, and social stratification. She employs a range of methods in her work, including quantitative methods, survey experiments, and both computational and qualitative analyses of text data.

Supplementary material

Supplementary Material is available at *Social Forces* online.

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Conflicts of interest

None declared.

Data availability

The data used for this study is publicly available through [Regulations.gov](https://www.regulations.gov) (docket OMB-2023-0001).

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